

Demake
By Otto Perry

*You pick up your 20th-anniversary omnibus of the original run of Zebraman comics.
You open it and begin to read a random page.*

Zebraman sits at the bar, a glass of whiskey clasped in his fingers. He is no normal man. After a petting zoo accident, his genetic makeup fused with that of a zebra, bringing great speed and, of course, the stripes. He looks like any sad sap except for his obvious black and white striped trench coat, always flapping in the non-existent wind.

With his late friend Zippo Man on his mind, he takes sips of his scotch.

ZEBRAMAN enters the bar with gusto, firing finger guns into an empty room.

Zebraman turns around at the sound, and he is shocked to find himself at the door. But it couldn't be him. This Zebraman is too colorful and too loud.

Zebraman takes a seat at the bar, turning towards the OTHER ZEBRAMAN. He opens his mouth to speak.

"Do you want my autograph or something?" Zebraman asks, his gaze sinking back into his glass.

Zebraman's mouth is agape for a moment before he speaks.

ZEBRAMAN

You should be the one asking me for an autograph!

Zebraman's sassy expression morphs into a grimace.

ZEBRAMAN (CONT'D)

I'm sorry. I'm not in full control of what I say.

(gulp)

I need you, the original Zebraman, for a favor. A little friend of mine should be here soon to explain the situation to you.

Zebraman quickly stands up, making his way towards the door. "Whatever weird shit you want me to do, forget it. I've already got a lot of shit on my mind and a whacko in tights saying he's me is the last thing I want to add to that pile," He grumbles on his way out.

Suddenly, something crashes through the window sending glass across the floor. Zebraman immediately pulls out dual pistols from his trench coat, filling the ceiling with lead. He stops firing after hearing a voice coming from the smoke.

"Holy shit dude, it's me! Another you. Chill the fuck out." The voice was his own, except transmitted through a tin can. As the smoke clears, the flying thing is revealed to be a floating robot, donning zebra stripes of course.

ZEBRAMAN

Well, that just happened!

Zebraman's face scrunches up and he puts his face into his hands.

ZEBRAMAN (CONT'D)

Oh god, not again...

Zebraman begins to sob.

The original Zebraman keeps his pistols drawn, eyeing his two doppelgangers. "I'll politely ask you two to fuck off back to whatever weird fan club you two crawled out of," he points one of his pistols at the sobbing Zebraman, "especially him, he gets on my nerves."

"You really are the original Zebraman! Taking shit from nobody!" ZebraBot cheers, its LED screen showing a digital grin. "If you're willing to hear me out, you'll be doing a service for a lot of people, most important of those being yourself."

"Ok, spill it quick before you and your buddy get remodeled." The original Zebraman puts his guns back up, looking between the two.

Zebraman cries out, tears still streaming past his fingers.

ZEBRAMAN

I need you to kill me!

"Not just him," Zebrabot explains, "you need to kill every iteration of you that came after the first. If you already couldn't tell, you are the first in a line of remakes and adaptations. You are a character beloved by many, tarnished by the trash created to try and emulate your badassery."

"So, I'm not real?" Zebraman asks, pressing his knuckle against his chin in thought.

"Don't think about it. I don't want you to go crazy before cleaning up your legacy." ZebraBot turns to the Zebraman on the barstool. "This freak is the movie version of you, and the

latest one. Forced to be the quippy hero that makes millions at the box office, or at least, used to make millions."

ZEBRAMAN

I just need you to end it. I can't see the color green without
going into a fit. I keep saying stupid shi-

(stops briefly)

Things! I keep saying things against my will. I can't keep doing
this. Please make it stop.

Zebraman considers his options, looking down at his silver pistols. "Ok, I'll do it if it means that it'll be better for my fans."

"Oh, I know it will be." Zebra Bot grins again.

ZEBRAMAN (CONT'D)

I don't want to look at you while you do it.

Zebraman points his face down before twisting around on the bar stool away from the other Zebraman.

"Do I have to do it here? I mean the owner is cowering over in that corn-"

"Just fucking do it already, we have a lot more of you to put in the ground." Zebra Bot commands.

Zebraman mutters something but ultimately puts a pistol to the head of the other Zebraman.

ZEBRAMAN

He's right behind me, isn't he? (in a sassy tone)

Zebraman is shot in the head, slumping over before flopping onto the floor. The pooling blood stains his black and white stripes.

"What's black and white and red all over?" Zebra Bot asks. Zebraman puts away his pistols, his eyes trained on the hole in the back of the dead man's head. "A dead Zebraman!"

Zebraman sighs.

"I killed him. He was me, but now he's no one." Zebraman holds his stare.

"Yep, classic Zebraman, always one to ruminate on what terrible things he's done. That's why you're so cool!" Zebra Bot spins around with a digital smile.

Zebraman sighs again. "Alright then, let's go," he asks, taking one last look at the former Zebraman before leaving the bar. Zebra Bot floats alongside him, as happy as a robot could be.